

Cadences

The term “cadence” describes how a phrase or a piece of music comes to a conclusion. Derived from the Latin verb *cadere*, which means “to fall,” a cadence is a type of settling, or rounding off.

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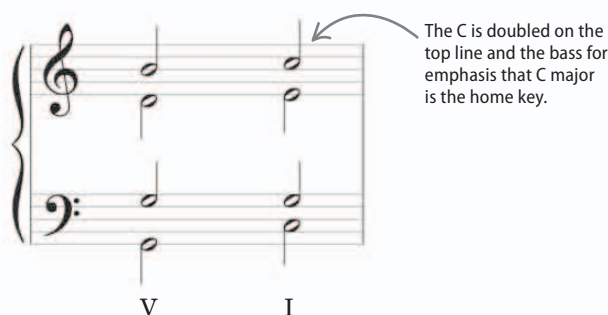
◀ 130–131 Chord types

The Baroque period

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Perfect cadence

The simplest and most conclusive cadence is a perfect cadence, where the feeling of completion comes from moving down from a chord on the dominant (the fifth) to the tonic (root), reasserting and strengthening the key signature.



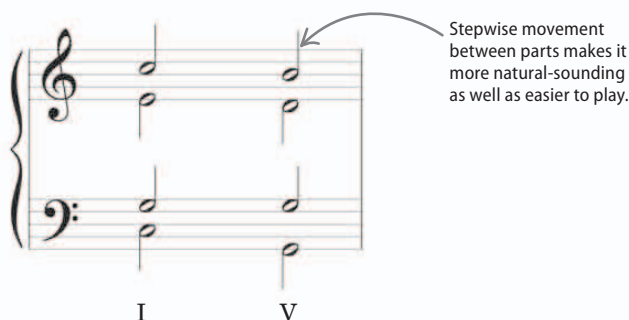
△ The 5–1 cadence

The dominant chord of C is G, which is arranged here to allow for a stepwise movement into a C chord (D to E and B to C).

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Imperfect cadence

In an imperfect cadence the last chord is chord V (the dominant) creating an unfinished effect. In the key of C, the second chord of an imperfect cadence would be the chord of G.



△ What next?

This reverses the movement of the perfect cadence, moving from C to G in C major. It would be strange or unusual to conclude an entire piece this way.

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Plagal cadence

A plagal cadence is often found in chorale harmonies and hymns. The subdominant (IV) has a greater feeling of openness than the dominant (V).



△ “Amen”

In the Christian tradition, this type of cadence in sacred music is often used for the final “Amen.”

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Interrupted cadence

A cadence that completes the phrase but suspends resolution by moving to a vi chord rather than I or V is called an interrupted cadence.



△ Cliffhanger

Although the VI chord in C major shares both C and E with the tonic, the A resolves to a different and slightly unexpected place, turning away from the expected tonic.

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